

Summer of Code

A Summer of Code is an event where students get compensated for coding for Open Source applications. Google and Ruby host SoC events, among others

The GNU license

Why do Open Source software require a license at all? This is because they don't want someone to come along and claim legal rights for the code, the license still protects the makers from theft, but in a different way



Rakshat Hooja

Rakshat Hooja is the Director of IDA Systems Pvt Ltd (www.idasystems.net), a company that specializes in selling Open Source Hardware in India. The company is the only authorized distributors of the Beagleboard and the Hawkboard in India. Some of his current projects include promoting the SHR mobile software, and open source alternative firmware for Smartphones, and on the fully open hardware Ben Nanonote mini computer. He firmly believes that users should have complete control of their hardware and software, and have the freedom to modify these for individual purposes. We asked him why the FOSS movement was so important. "I hate arbitrary limitations and designed obsolescence. Phones are a good example; why should I need to buy a new handset to get a feature the existing hardware is capable of, and supposed to have, but doesn't because of botched firmware the manufacturer has decided not to fix? Why is this simple software feature only available on the 'pro' model at 3 times the price, or not available at all?"

Finally I find the faults somehow less irritating when I know I could fix them if I could be bothered." There is a powerful and thoroughly commercial justification for FOSS as well, according to Rakshat "custom software on an existing open platform can make small market niches commercially viable when they wouldn't be otherwise."

One of the items listed on IDA Systems that really caught our eye was Pandora, an open source hardware platform for portable gaming, which will start selling in India before August 2010. Its ready and undergoing final assembly right now.

Jack Low

Jack Low is currently working on a bunch of FOSS projects. Jack is responsible for packaging OpenOffice for FreeBSD, so users don't have to spend ages compiling OpenOffice from source. He also works on the Audacity port for FreeBSD. He has worked on a lot of IRC related projects in the past, most of them for his own convenience, but like most FOSS tools, others benefitted from it. Jack L also runs a radio station called Punk Rock Demonstration at <http://www.punk-rockdemo.com> which is also 100% free.

We asked Jack how newbies can sign up and get involved, "Newbies can easily participate by finding a project they are interested in. If you're interested enough and have an urge to make it better, then you're set. It might be a little hard to get some of the concepts, but it's a very good learning experience. Even the best programmers were newbies once." He



has been a part of the FOSS movement for a long time now, and we asked him why the FOSS movement was important. "The FOSS movement is very important to me because I wouldn't have anything to use if it wasn't for FOSS. I use an open source operating system "FreeBSD" and all my software is free or open source. I don't think software made by people that get paid are of the best quality work and software that cost an arm and a leg are not fair for the people who can't afford it. It also doesn't allow room for improvement or technological advancements when software is in a binary form only." Like many FOSS enthusiasts, a "software" according to Jack does not stop at the executable, but includes the source code and good documentation as well.



Vikram Vincent

Vikram Vincent is primarily involved in promoting the application of FOSS based educational technology to the Indian education system. He also contributes to Debian-GNOME IIOn. Vikram is involved in localising Debian distros for the Indian environment. Vikram is full of ideas on how individuals can contribute to FOSS, "There are different ways to participate in the FOSS movement" he says "One can write code, translate free software to the mother tongue, evangelise about free software among schools-college students, conduct FOSS workshops-seminars, teach some under-privileged kids to use various educational tools and start free software user groups in your place of study or work." He also mentions FSMK when asked about how students can contribute on a more active level. "A community like the Free Software Movement Karnataka(FSMK) follows the approach of reaching out to the student and teacher communities and extends support to them in the form of workshops, project mentorships, networking, etc. The latest Google Summer of Code has shown that Indian students are the second highest participants. So it may be inferred that the entry barrier is being lowered by the students' awareness and efforts of FOSS groups all over India. The activities mentioned in the previous point are normally the starting points." Vikram, like many FOSS enthusiasts, strongly believes that users should have more control of technology, or freedom in other words. "The FOSS movement has the germs of creative thinking and problem solving to issues of the ordinary human being. The most important ideas are those of intellectual, socio-economic and cultural freedoms that it promotes." 